Faculty of economic and management

International bachelor of business and economics

Saint-Petersburg 2025

The ICU branding agency SWOT analysis project

6 team:
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Osina Anastasia 247

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ICU branding agency

– creates connections between businesses and audiences through deep research and creative thinking.

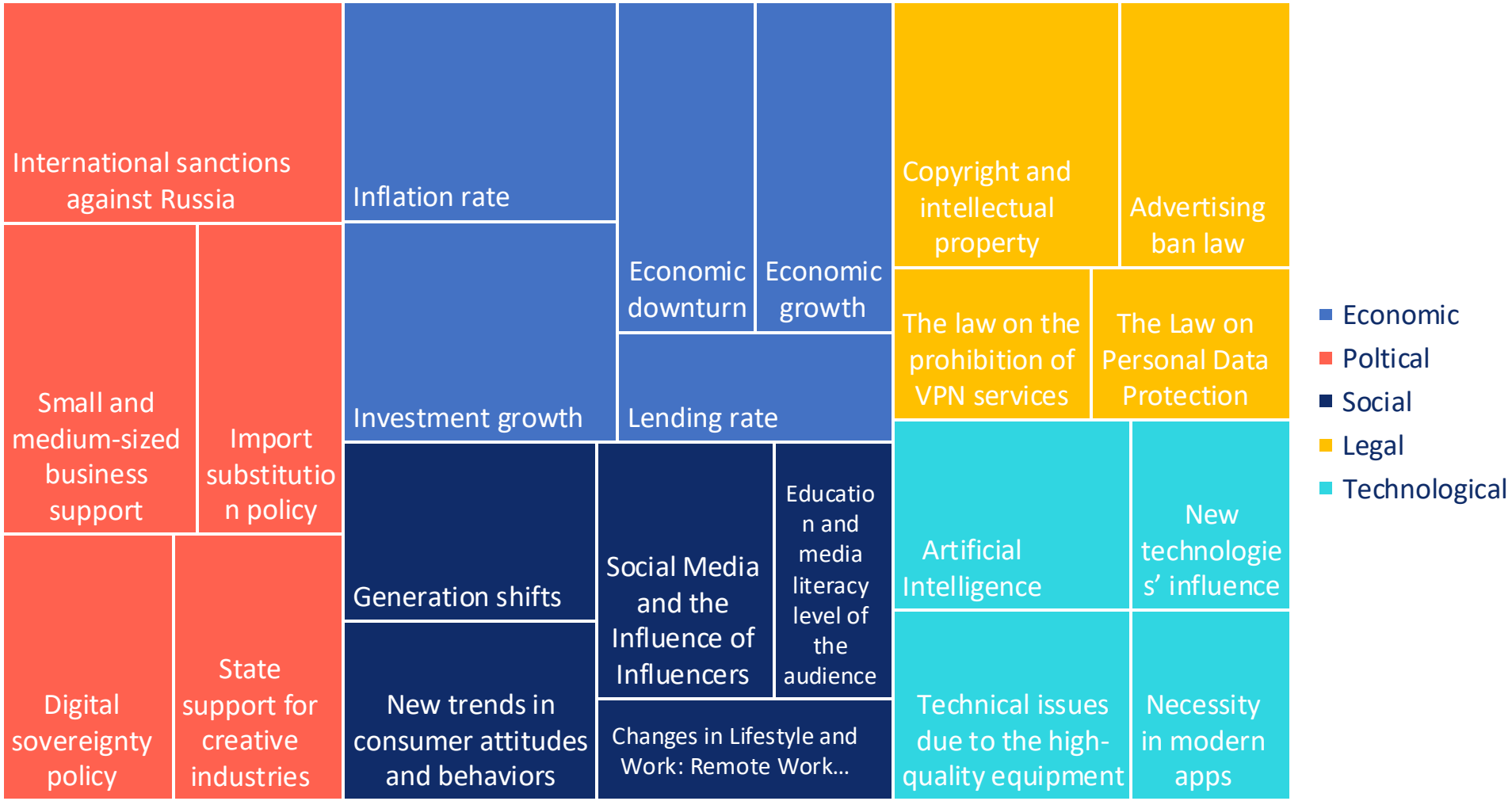
- **15** years on the market
- **Top 5** in Runet rating
- Members of **ABCR** and **ACAR**
- **1000+** projects implemented

1 Complex branding
2 Brand-platform
3 Product package
4 Signature style
5 Corporate identity
6 Brand book



7 Advertisement creative
8 Social media marketing
9 Naming
10 Rebranding
11 Communication strategy
12 Neuro branding

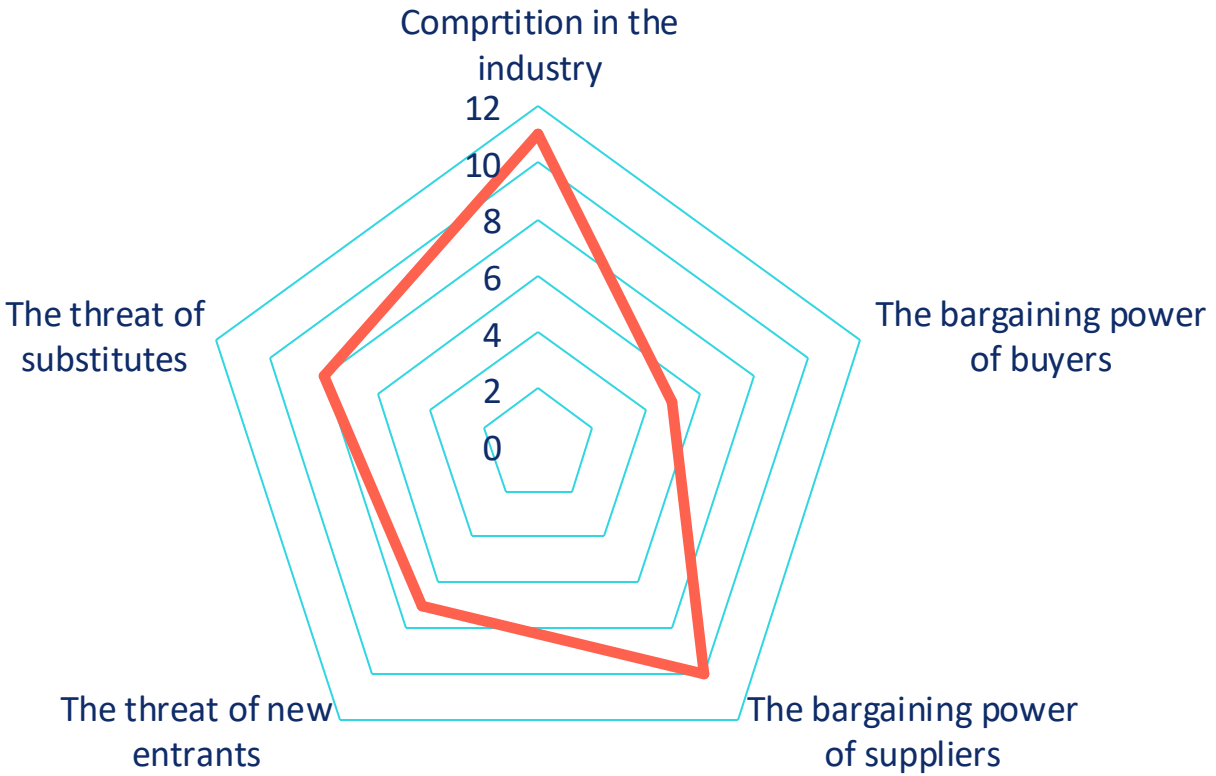
PESTEL


International sanctions against Russia
Inflation rate
Economic downturn
Economic growth
Copyright and intellectual property
Advertising ban law
Small and medium-sized business support
Import substitution policy
Investment growth
Lending rate
The law on the prohibition of VPN services
The Law on Personal Data Protection
Generation shifts
Social Media and the Influence of Influencers
Education and media literacy level of the audience
Artificial Intelligence
New technologies' influence
Digital sovereignty policy
State support for creative industries
New trends in consumer attitudes and behaviors
Changes in Lifestyle and Work: Remote Work...
Technical issues due to the high-quality equipment
Necessity in modern apps
Economic
Poltical
Social
Legal
Technological

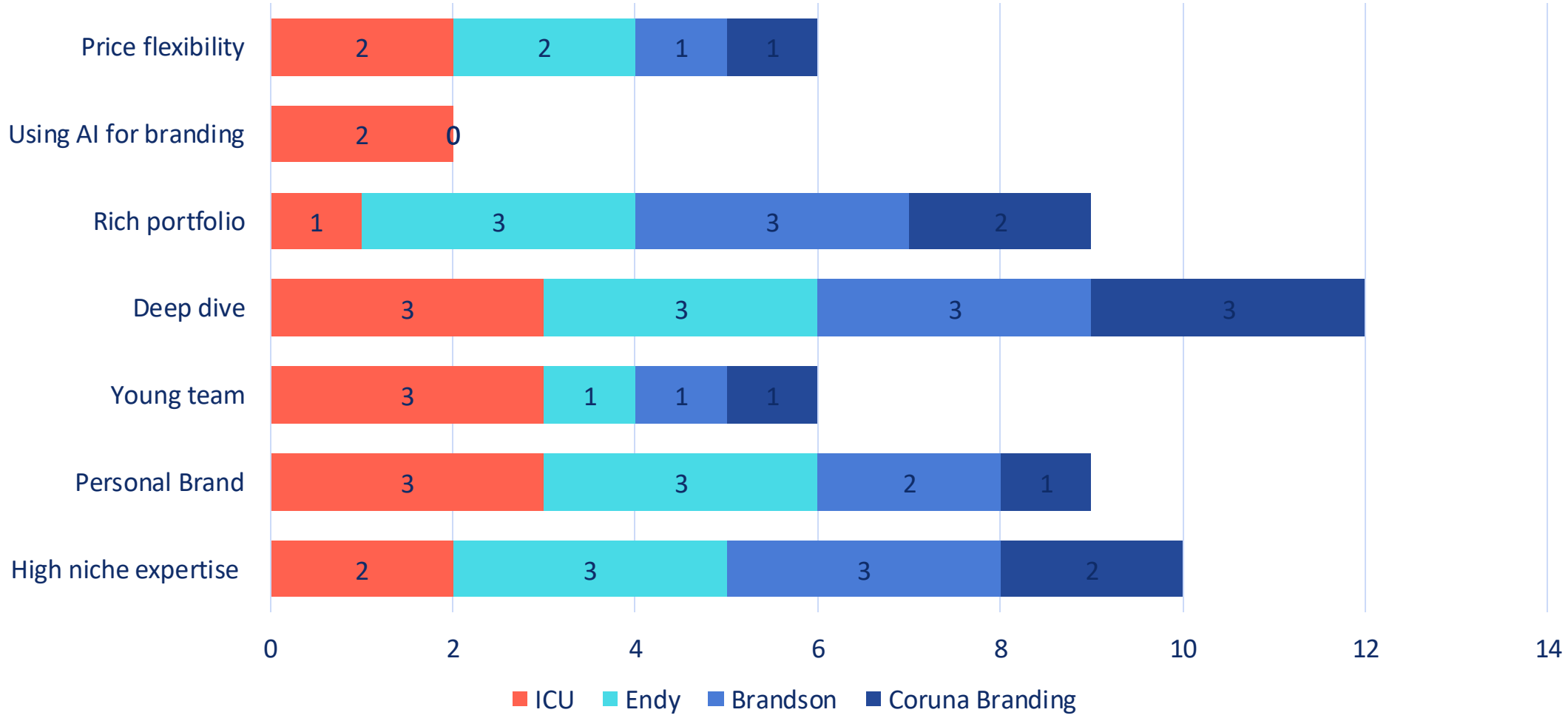
Porter's 5 forces

Alignment forces

- Competition in the industry – **11** (high level)
- Bargaining power of buyers – **5** (low level)
- The bargaining power of suppliers – **10** (high level)
- The threat of new entrants – **7** (average level)
- The threat of substitutes – **8** (average level)



KSF


Price flexibility
2
2
1
1
Using AI for branding
2
0
Rich portfolio
1
3
3
2
Deep dive
3
3
3
3
Young team
3
1
1
1
Personal Brand
3
3
2
1
High niche expertise
2
3
3
2
0
2
4
6
8
10
12
14
ICU
Endy
Brandson
Coruna Branding

Primary SWOT

Internal

Strengths

1. Deep research and individual approach
2. High level of credibility and reputation
3. Broad specialization
4. Remote work format
5. Innovations and observation

Weaknesses

1. Lack of clear self-positioning
2. Limited funding
3. Dependence on external performers
4. Weak portfolio, many cases on design that do not show the branding results
5. Poorly developed education sector

External

Opportunities

1. Increased recognition through collaborations
2. Participation in new markets, including foreign
3. Deepening expertise through educational products
4. Active, developed social media
5. Partnership with consulting agencies

Threats

1. Plagiarism and leakage of ideas on the Internet
2. High costs on the background of freelance structure
3. Dependence on platforms and subscriptions
4. Law difficulties
5. Sensitive markets depended on economic situation

Extended SWOT

SO

S4O1O3: ICU employees can work remotely, collaborate with freelancers from all over the world, and conduct webinars to increase awareness and attract more talent.

S3S4O2: ICU having a wide range of services and remote workers can offer branding for small and medium enterprises in the CIS.

S2O1O2: cooperate with foreign companies and entry new markets

S5O4: ICU is a company that talks about the use of AI in their projects (neurobranding) without hesitation. In this context, it would be beneficial to conduct a series of podcasts on the usage of AI in branding.

WO

W4O3O4: launch educational courses that demonstrate developing ICU projects to strengthen their portfolio.

W5O2O3: courses in English can be provided for foreign companies and CIS companies to enhance their understanding of the Russian branding market.

W2O1O3: collaboration with online schools to create branding courses can help increase limited funding and generate additional revenue.

W1W3O4: lack of clear self-positioning can be an advantage in social media. Posting about the significance of each direction can increase confidence in the agency from clients and attract new employees.

Extended SWOT

ST

S4T2T3: collaboration with startups by barter. ICU give them promotion and startups provide their platforms.

S3S5T1T4: patent a product using creative commons and NFT.

S2T5: ICU's high reputation will be an important factor for clients when choosing a branding agency in a difficult economic situation.

S1T5: through in-depth research and a personalized approach, ICU will be able to tailor a strategy for the individual promotion of clients during difficult economic situation.

WT

W2T4: hiring a permanent in-house lawyer may avoid any legal issues with drafting contracts, hiring employees, in accordance with changing laws, and it also ensures legal security for the business at all levels.

W3T1: focusing on the content that is viral on the Internet, making an attractive creatives for promoting their company as a professionals with rich experience and creative thinking, thus ICU improve their portfolio.

W1W5T2: organizing online courses, free lectures in institutions and forums can help ICU identify itself in the market, find its own style and attract young motivated specialists, thus reducing the company's costs for recruiting employees.

W3W2T3T5: In critical situations, outsourcing is a way to save ICU's resources.

Strategic alternatives

S2O1O2: Cooperate with foreign companies and entry new markets.

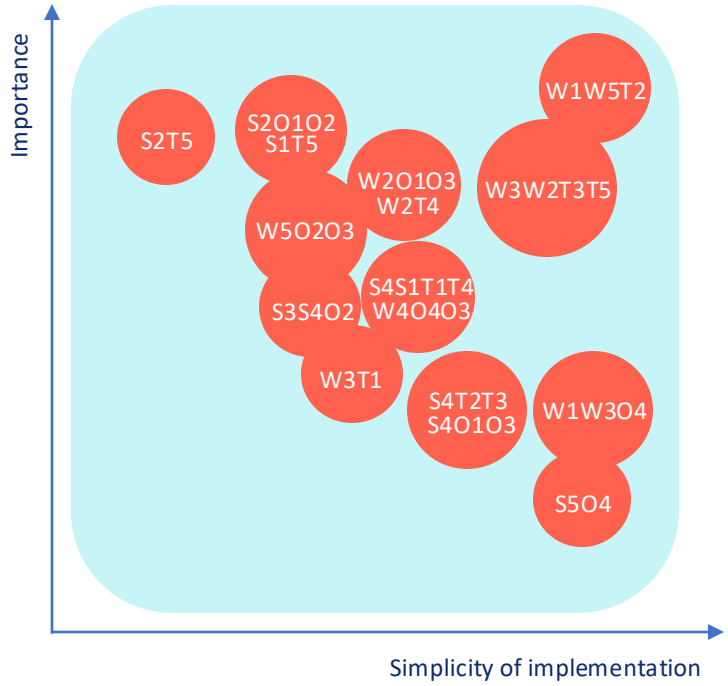
To strengthen its position and reputation in the Russian market, ICU should partner with foreign agencies. This will help ICU expand into international markets and attract foreign clients.

W1W5T2: Education: online courses, lectures and forums.

ICU should launch an educational program and scale it to enhance the sector. Success would attract clients and talent, while failure may lead to a freemium model with partner monetization.

W3W2T3T5: In critical situations, outsourcing is a way to save ICU's resources.

Outsourcing lets ICU cut costs on non-core tasks but risks losing control and complicating reintegration.



S2O1O2: Cooperate with foreign companies and entry new markets.

Steps/Month	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Choose region to focus on	■											
Conduct market analysis of chosen location	■											
Find potential partner companies	■											
Go to exhibition dedicated to branding and marketing sphere and try to get to know potential partners		■	■	■	■							
Proved them with opportunity to participate in Russian market						■						
Negotiate with company project in their market							■					
Execute the project								■	■			
Add new work into portfolio										■		
Continue evolving in the new market											■	■

S2O1O2: Cooperate with foreign companies and entry new markets.

The expected results

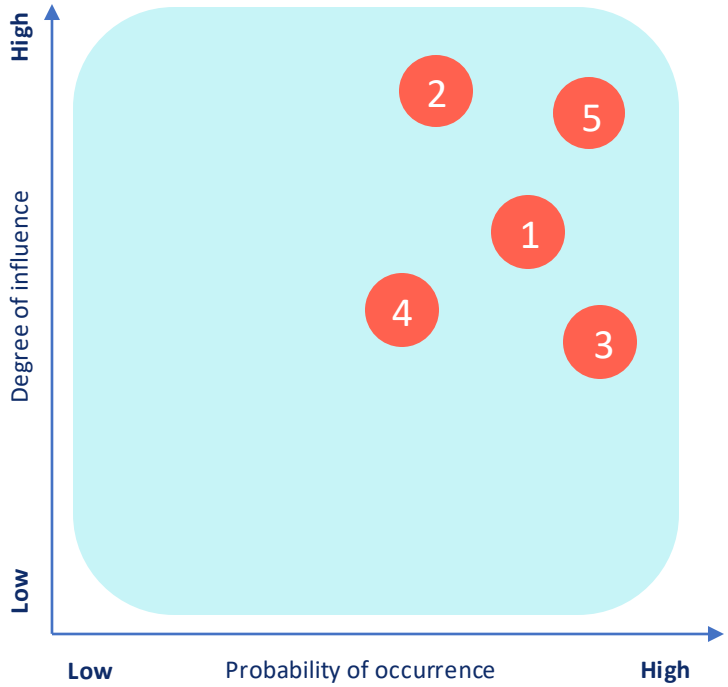
1. Strengthening in the foreign market
2. Increase their profits through new projects
3. Growth of reputation
4. Exchange of experience and ideas

S2O1O2: Cooperate with foreign companies and entry new markets.

Risks and their mitigation

	Risks	Minimization techniques
1	Legal problems due to regulatory differences	Hire lawyers with experience in the target market
2	Lack of knowledge and cultural difference	Hire a cultural manager. Provide tutoring for the employees about the partner's country culture
3	Cash flow problems	To plan all expenses in advance, utilize prepayment
4	Another technological infrastructure	Analyse applications that partners use and provide tutoring about them for employees
5	High costs of entering the new market	Use free promotion channels and analyse and use available state support programs

Risks matrix



Strategic alternatives

S2O1O2: Cooperate with foreign companies and entry new markets.

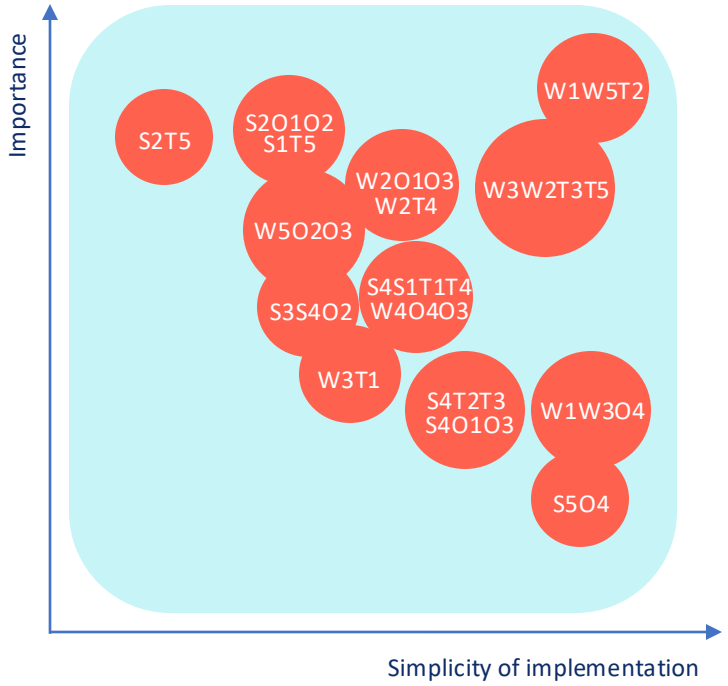
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W1W5T2: Education: online courses, lectures and forums.

Steps/Month	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Select the most highly qualified people from the team and bring in external methodologists												
Identify the target audience by conducting surveys and research												
Create a course structure with basic and advanced modules												
Choose the most appropriate format for each course (online/offline)												
Launch a pilot with a free mini-course for audience engagement and feedback												
Refinement and monetization												
Collaborations with app developers												
Scaling up: growing the team and investing in advertising												
Adding courses and international expansion												

W1W5T2: Education: online courses, lectures and forums.

The expected results

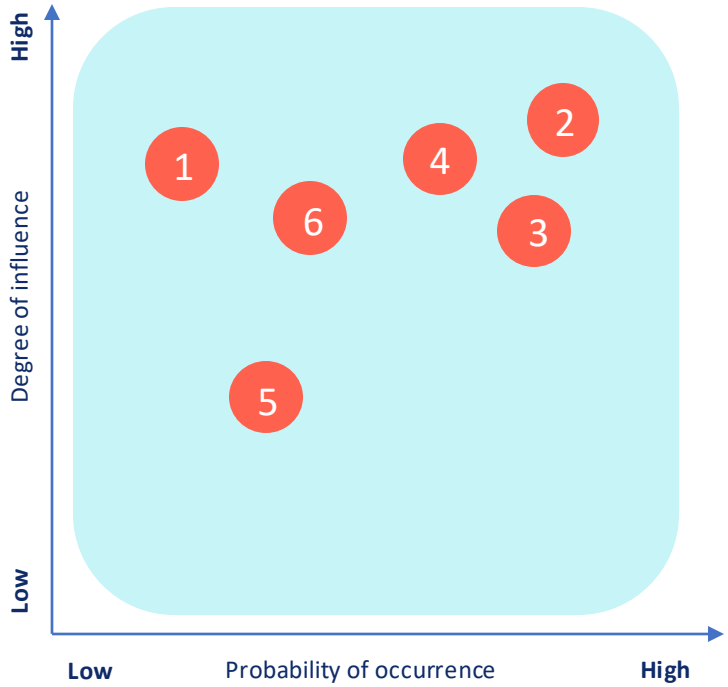
1. Increase in the number of corporate clients (5+)
2. Increase the share of educational services in ICU revenue to 20%
3. Increased brand recognition
4. Best students - unique and highly qualified specialists
5. Additional income covering part of operating expenses (up to 30%)

W1W5T2: Education: online courses, lectures and forums.

Risks and their mitigation

	Risks	Minimization techniques
1	Low demand for paid programs	Demonstrating uniqueness through emphasis on practical cases. Flexible monetization
2	Competition with free analogies	Compulsory employment for the best apprentices in ICU or partner companies
3	Lack of funding and delays in payments from customers	Apply for grants, set aside some capital for force majeure
4	Platform problems	Select options with backup platforms to switch to in case of force majeure
5	Low quality of content	Quality control, mandatory pilot run. Money back guarantee
6	Changes in education legislation and blocking of foreign services	Hire in-house counsel to keep abreast of changes in the law

Risks matrix



Strategic alternatives

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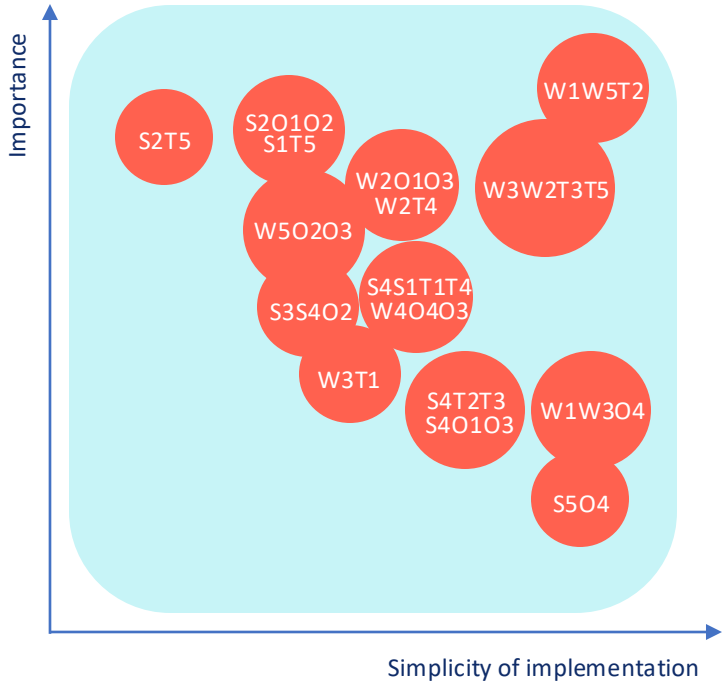
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W3W2T3T5: In critical situations, outsourcing is a way to save ICU's resources.

Steps/Month	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Identification of functions to be outsourced - allocation of non-core tasks, cost analysis	■	■										
Consultation with lawyers, risk assessment	■	■										
Search and selection of contractors			■	■								
Pilot projects - test period for new personnel					■	■						
Integration and continuous monitoring, redundancy of critical functions							■	■	■			

W3W2T3T5: In critical situations, outsourcing is a way to save ICU's resources.

The expected results

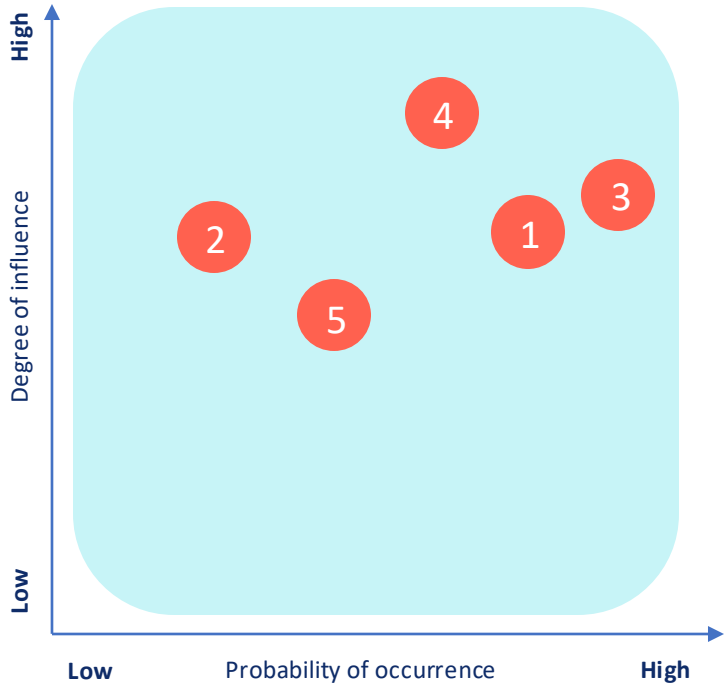
1. Setting clear SLAs and implementing mandatory quarterly reports that reflect the quality of the work done.
2. Budget savings
3. Free time and energy for specialized tasks
4. Scalability, rapid growth without increasing staffing levels
5. Compensation for staff shortages

W3W2T3T5: In critical situations, outsourcing is a way to save ICU's resources.

Risks and their mitigation

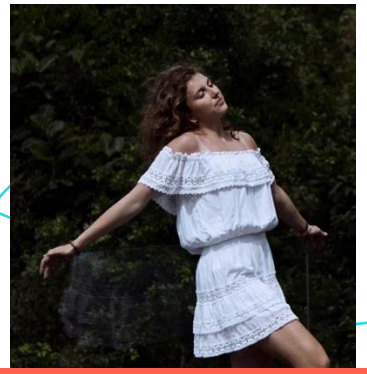
	Risks	Minimization techniques
1	Loss of control over processors	Setting clear SLAs and implementing mandatory quarterly reports
2	Reduced quality of services	Conducting mandatory internships before official employment for a short period to understand the level of professionalism
3	Data leakage and privacy violations	Signing an NDA with strict criteria and penalties
4	Dependence on an outsourcer	
5	Additional costs in unforeseen circumstances	Using a transparent payment system, the employee receives a salary upon completion of the work

Risks matrix





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